

TOKYO CALLING

REUTERS/MICHAEL DALDER

With the Japanese prime minister's visit, bilateral relations are all set to reach a new high, as Japan expects India to play a major role in Asia

■ By Saurabh Shukla in Tokyo

There is an eerie calm at the Liberal Democratic Party (LDP) headquarters in the heart of Tokyo. The ruling party has just suffered its worst drubbing in 55 years in the elections for the Upper House, with the Democratic Party of Japan (DPJ) wresting control of the Diet, the Japanese Parliament. While Prime Minister Shinzo Abe's key aides are busy with political damage control amidst calls for his resignation, he has indicated that he wants his trip to India to go as per schedule. For Abe, an Indophile, the engagement with India has always been a priority. "Ours is a win-win relationship. We have to leverage each other's growth; we want it to be a model partnership," says Yasuo Fukuda, an influential Diet member of LDP, who, many believe, might succeed Abe.

Not far from the party headquarters, at the entrance of the Japanese Ministry of Foreign Affairs, a poster of the Festival of India greets you—a clear indication that Japan's relationship with India remains important. "We consider India one of our most important diplomatic partners. Prime Minister Abe's visit will take the relationship to a new level," says Shimsuke Shimizu, head of the South Asia desk at the Japanese Foreign Office.

Abe has a lot on his agenda for his Delhi visit, including agreements on a \$90-billion (Rs 3.6 lakh crore) freight corridor between Delhi and Mumbai, besides an industrial corridor. He is also looking at increasing Japan's overseas development assistance to India, which currently stands at \$1.15 billion (Rs 4,600 crore). With Tokyo seeking to widen the canvas of its engagement



with India, a dozen vice-chancellors of Japanese universities will travel with Abe to hold talks with the heads of the top Indian universities. The idea is to boost people-to-people contacts.

The Japanese prime minister—a champion of environmental protection known for his "Cool Earth 50" proposals for the reduction of greenhouse gas emission and the formation of an international framework to address global warming—is expected to help India achieve energy efficiency. Since Japan will host the G-8 summit next year—where climate change will be on the top of the agenda—Abe is likely to discuss clean energy and environment issues with Prime Minister Manmohan Singh when he meets him at Hyderabad

House in Delhi on August 22.

In what is seen as a candid acknowledgement of India's growing presence in Asia, Abe is focusing only on India. He is not visiting Islamabad. He will address a joint session of Parliament—an honour not extended by the Indian Government even to leaders like US President George Bush and Chinese Premier Hu Jintao.

Even as the Japanese Foreign Office braces for the visit, officials of Japan's Ministry of Defence want closer strategic cooperation, taking into account China's nuclear and missile development. "We need to keep a close watch on their expansion of marine activity and modernisation of their navy and air force," explains a senior

